

ROCKY: THE ROCKEFELLER CHRISTMAS TREE

The Little Tree with Big Dreams

ANIMATED FEATURE BEAT BOARD

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STORY ENGINE

A small, crooked Norway spruce dreams of becoming the Rockefeller Christmas Tree. His path tests whether belief means becoming perfect - or choosing courage, service, and persistence when the dream costs him something.

RECURRING VISUAL MOTIFS

Thin light / one green needle / Rocky's crooked top / Mary Louise's glow / the silver mirror / the red ribbon / frozen-dew ornaments / helicopters / snow / the phrase "top of the world."

33 major visual beats | Three-act structure | Built directly from the screenplay

ACT ONE

BEAT 1

THE HIDDEN FOREST WAKES

The season's first snow hits the Hidden Forest. Animals scramble, reindeer drill, and news races from branch to branch: the Rockefeller Christmas Tree choosing has begun.

VISUAL: Wide aerial over a snowy evergreen valley; comic animal activity below; two ancient Oaks anchoring the forest.

FUNCTION: Story setup

BEAT 2

MEET ROCKY

Far from the excitement, Rocky stands in a gray hollow with thin soil and one shaft of sun. Small, patchy, brown, and crooked, he strains to stand straight and hears the news.

VISUAL: Tiny crooked Norway spruce alone in a dim hollow; bright forest celebration visible high above him.

FUNCTION: Protagonist / visual contrast

BEAT 3

THE CHOOSING

The forest gathers beneath the Oaks. Great trees volunteer. Bruce Spruce does not bother appearing; he assumes the judges can find him. From far below comes Rocky's small voice: "I do."

VISUAL: Grand trees rise like mountains around a packed forest crowd; Rocky is barely visible in the distant hollow.

FUNCTION: Inciting decision

BEAT 4

THE FOREST LAUGHS

Rocky declares himself a candidate. The animals laugh. AJ turns Rocky's weakness into a song, and Mrs. Pickles asks what could make Rocky think he belongs among the grandest trees.

VISUAL: Rocky surrounded by laughing animals; AJ performing; Mrs. Pickles studying him over her silver mirror.

FUNCTION: Public humiliation

BEAT 5

THE STORY OF THE CHOSEN TREE

At dusk, Old Oak tells the young ones what happens to the chosen tree: a trip to New York, lights before the whole world, and a final place among past Rockefeller trees at the North Pole. Rocky recites the ending alone; he has memorized it.

VISUAL: Storybook images suspended in falling snow: New York lights, crowds, northern lights, rows of glowing trees.

FUNCTION: Theme / dream

BEAT 6

BRUCE ENTERS THE HOLLOW

Bruce Spruce arrives after dark with AJ perched in his branches. He towers over Rocky, tells him he cannot win, and urges him to withdraw. Rocky trembles but refuses to be scared off.

VISUAL: Bruce's enormous silhouette erases the stars over Rocky; AJ imitates Bruce from a branch.

FUNCTION: Antagonist pressure

BEAT 7

MARY LOUISE

A teacup-sized fairy drives Bruce away. Mary Louise introduces herself as Guardian of the Forest. Rocky asks her to make him handsome and strong. She refuses the shortcut: there is no magic; he must believe.

VISUAL: Tiny glowing fairy nose-to-nose with huge Bruce, followed by warm light around Rocky and Mary Louise.

FUNCTION: Mentor / thematic rule

BEAT 8

ONE GREEN NEEDLE

Alone, Rocky begins his mantra: "I am tall, fluffy, and green." Nothing changes at first. He keeps going. One bent branch produces a single deep-green needle.

VISUAL: Close-up: one glossy green needle against Rocky's brown branch and gray snowfall.

FUNCTION: Act One turn

ACT TWO

BEAT 9

GROWTH TAKES WORK

Rocky reaches for water, stretches into his sliver of sun, repeats his words through snow and doubt, and slowly grows. His branches unfold; his color deepens; he finally calls across the forest, "Look at me!"

VISUAL: Growth montage: root touching water, snow burying Rocky, branches opening into sunlight.

FUNCTION: Progress

BEAT 10

ROCKY PASSES IT ON

Five struggling saplings, led by Pip, ask how Rocky changed. Rocky gives them Mary Louise's lesson and teaches them the mantra. He spends time helping them instead of focusing only on himself.

VISUAL: Rocky leaning down to five crooked saplings lined up with eyes closed; Pip shouting the wrong ending.

FUNCTION: Character growth

BEAT 11

BRUCE BELIEVES IT IS MAGIC

Mrs. Pickles and AJ decide Rocky's transformation must be a spell. AJ tells Bruce. Watching Rocky from the shadows, Bruce decides Mary Louise must have changed him and plans to trap her.

VISUAL: Bruce and AJ in shadow, watching green Rocky glow on the opposite slope.

FUNCTION: Rising threat

BEAT 12

THE FAIRY TRAP

Bruce builds a crude twig net. AJ watches Mary Louise's tiny house as she makes the champion's ornaments. Bruce catches her and threatens her home unless she changes Rocky.

VISUAL: Huge Bruce swinging a tiny twig net over glowing Mary Louise near her pebble-and-leaf house.

FUNCTION: Villain action

BEAT 13

JUDGING MORNING

Rocky stands magnificent as the judges' helicopters approach. Hidden behind a snow mound, Mary Louise calls for help. Rocky sees his lifelong dream in one direction and her prison in the other.

VISUAL: Rocky lit by morning sun; helicopters on horizon; faint glow behind snow mound.

FUNCTION: Moral choice

BEAT 14

ROCKY TEARS UP HIS ROOTS

Rocky chooses Mary Louise. He rips his roots from frozen ground and drags himself down the slope, losing color and needles as the judges begin their pass.

VISUAL: Explosive frozen soil around uprooted Rocky; a torn trench behind him; helicopters overhead.

FUNCTION: Sacrifice

BEAT 15

AJ CHANGES SIDES

Rocky struggles with the net. Mary Louise tells Aj there was never a spell; Rocky changed through belief and effort. Aj opens the net, helping Rocky free her as the helicopters thunder overhead.

VISUAL: Gray Rocky pulling the net; Aj's paws opening knots; Mary Louise bursting upward in light.

FUNCTION: Aj's turn

BEAT 16

BRUCE WINS

Rocky drags himself home, gray and broken. The helicopters pass over him and circle Bruce. A red champion's ribbon settles around Bruce as Rocky stands alone in his hollow.

VISUAL: Foreground: battered Rocky at attention; distant ridge: helicopters circling ribboned Bruce.

FUNCTION: False defeat

BEAT 17

ROCKY STOPS BELIEVING

Rocky refuses to repeat his words and grows grayer. Mary Louise offers no second rescue. Mrs. Pickles quietly sits beside him and places her mirror face-down in the snow.

VISUAL: Gray Rocky and Mrs. Pickles sitting in silence at dusk; silver mirror face-down.

FUNCTION: Dark stretch

BEAT 18

AJ SINGS A NEW SONG

Aj returns and awkwardly rewrites his old taunt into praise. He pushes Rocky to say his own words again. A single needle rises. Pip and the saplings arrive and join him.

VISUAL: Aj singing badly in front of Rocky; saplings gathering; one green needle visible.

FUNCTION: Recovery

BEAT 19

ROCKY RETURNS AS HIMSELF

Rocky's green returns slowly. He does not regain the flawless form he once had. He becomes a stronger version of his real, crooked self and keeps helping the saplings.

VISUAL: Rocky mostly green, still crooked, supervising saplings at the stream.

FUNCTION: Internal victory

BEAT 20

THE ICE STORM

Freezing rain turns the forest to glass. Rocky braces the bending saplings and talks Pip through his fear. A deep split sounds from the far ridge: Bruce is breaking under his own frozen weight.

VISUAL: Ice-coated forest under violent wind; Rocky holding five saplings upright.

FUNCTION: External test

BEAT 21

ROCKY SAVES BRUCE

Rocky crosses the ridge and braces his smaller trunk against Bruce's splitting flank. The tree who mocked him spends the night supported by the tree he beat.

VISUAL: Small Rocky jammed beneath massive cracked Bruce, both covered in ice.

FUNCTION: Forgiveness / courage

BEAT 22

THE CHAMPION'S ORNAMENTS

During the same storm, Rocky reaches into Mary Louise's damaged bramble house and shelters the delicate ornaments she made for the champion.

VISUAL: Rocky's iced branch cupping tiny frozen-dew globes and snowflake star against the wind.

FUNCTION: Symbolic payoff

BEAT 23

THE PERFECT TREE

At dawn, Bruce survives but cannot be lit. The saplings stand. Rocky, exhausted and ice-crowned, catches the sunrise. The returning helicopters stop over his hollow: "We found the perfect tree!"

VISUAL: Rocky glazed in ice, throwing sunrise into a thousand bright fragments; helicopters circling overhead.

FUNCTION: Climax of Act Two

BEAT 24

BRUCE TELLS THE TRUTH

Bruce reaches Rocky's celebration and publicly confesses the trap. He tells the forest Rocky sacrificed his first chance to rescue Mary Louise and declares the judges chose the right tree.

VISUAL: Split, ribbon-damaged Bruce bowing deeply before ice-crowned Rocky and the silent forest.

FUNCTION: Resolution / Bruce's turn

ACT THREE

BEAT 25

THE SAW

Celebration ends when a truck arrives carrying a saw. Rocky learns what "carried out of the forest" really means. Frightened, he accepts the cost of his dream and says yes.

VISUAL: Rocky facing the long wrapped saw; forest gathered in a silent ring.

FUNCTION: Threshold

BEAT 27

THE ROAD TO NEW YORK

Rocky rides a flatbed into a world larger than his forest. AJ reveals he stowed away. Mrs. Pickles has come too. Towns cheer from overpasses; truckers silently toast Rocky. Bruce follows on another flatbed.

VISUAL: Night highway; Rocky netted on truck; AJ in branches; Mrs. Pickles by ropes; distant Bruce truck.

FUNCTION: Road sequence

BEAT 29

CRUSHED IN THE PLAZA

The netting comes off. Travel has crushed one side of Rocky; his color has dulled. Crew members wonder whether the bigger tree should have been chosen. Night falls, leaving Rocky bent and alone.

VISUAL: Small battered Rocky beneath towering buildings and empty scaffolding.

FUNCTION: Final crisis

BEAT 26

GOODBYE TO THE FOREST

Pip clings to Rocky. Mrs. Pickles cannot finish her prepared remarks. Mary Louise gives Rocky the ornaments he protected. As the saw starts, the entire forest bows.

VISUAL: Forest bowing as Rocky is carried away; Mary Louise's basket tucked safely in his branches.

FUNCTION: Departure

BEAT 28

THE WORLD STANDS UP

Rocky enters New York City. Towers rise around him like the Old Oak's story made real. At Rockefeller Center, a crane lifts him over Fifth Avenue and plants him in the center of the plaza.

VISUAL: Rocky suspended high over Manhattan with tiny taxis and crowds below.

FUNCTION: Arrival / dream made physical

BEAT 30

HE BELIEVES FOR EVERYONE ELSE

Rocky sees the empty chairs waiting for families who will come to see something beautiful. He repeats his words, no longer for judges or rivalry. Branch by branch, he opens and turns green as snow falls between the towers.

VISUAL: Empty midnight plaza; Rocky's branches rising one by one in fresh snow.

FUNCTION: Final internal choice

BEAT 31

THE LIGHTING

The plaza fills. Mary Louise secretly hangs the ornaments and snowflake star. Mrs. Pickles finally sees what makes Rocky grand. Bruce watches quietly from the rink. A switch is thrown and Rocky explodes into color before thousands.

VISUAL: Full Rockefeller Center lighting: Rocky glowing gold, green, red and blue; crowd below; Mary Louise circling near his star.

FUNCTION: Public climax

BEAT 33

THE TOP OF THE WORLD

In the storybook North Pole, generations of Rockefeller trees open a space for Rocky. He stands among them, lit and laughing, his champion's star at his crooked tip. The once-clumsy reindeer finally clears every drift.

VISUAL: Northern lights over endless white; rows of glowing Christmas trees; Rocky welcomed into the center.

FUNCTION: Final image

BEAT 32

ONE MORE GIFT

After the lights come down, Rocky's wood becomes part of a family's small home. The following winter, Pip asks Old Oak to tell where Rocky is now.

VISUAL: Warm spring house under construction, dissolving to Pip beneath snowy Oaks the next winter.

FUNCTION: Epilogue bridge

BEAT BOARD - PRODUCTION NOTES

Character progression: Rocky begins wanting to become a different tree. His first growth is physical. His deeper growth arrives after he sacrifices the contest, loses, rebuilds himself with help, saves others, and finally chooses to stand tall in New York for the people coming to see him.

Visual escalation: Gray hollow -> green transformation -> torn roots and gray defeat -> glass-like ice storm -> ice crown -> saw and departure -> vertical New York -> empty midnight plaza -> full Rockefeller Center illumination -> North Pole storybook image.

Boarding priority: The strongest pitch images are Beats 2, 5, 7, 8, 14, 16, 21, 23, 26, 28, 30, 31, and 33. These can become the first key-art/storyboard frames if the board is later expanded into illustrated panels.

Source: ROCKY: THE ROCKEFELLER CHRISTMAS TREE - The Little Tree with Big Dreams, animated family feature screenplay by Jennie E. Nicassio.